Magdara B. Dimaampao

Magdara B. Dimaampao (c. 1933 to July 11, 2013) was a Maranao jurist, diplomat, and public servant from Lanao del Sur who carved out a career that touched three of the most consequential institutions in Philippine public life: the judiciary, the foreign service, and the Commission on Elections.

He is perhaps best remembered today as the father of Supreme Court Associate Justice Japar B. Dimaampao, but Magdara's own record stands on its own terms. Across decades of service, he moved through roles as a city judge, a diplomat to the Middle East, and eventually a commissioner of one of the Philippines' constitutional bodies, making him one of the most broadly experienced Muslim Filipino public servants of his generation.

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EARLY LIFE AND EDUCATION

Magdara B. Dimaampao was born around 1933 in Lanao del Sur, the heartland of the Maranao people in the southern Philippines. He came of age during a period of significant transition for the country, one that was still finding its post-war footing and working through the complex relationship between the central government and the Muslim south.

Growing up Maranao meant growing up with a strong sense of identity rooted in maratabat, in community, and in the structures of traditional leadership. That cultural grounding would stay with Dimaampao throughout his public life, showing up in the way he navigated institutions that were, at the time, largely shaped by and for non-Muslim Filipinos.

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Personal Information

Born: c. 1933, Lanao del Sur, Philippines

Died: July 11, 2013 (aged approx. 80)

Nationality

Filipino

Ethnicity

Maranao

Education

Bachelor of Laws; Philippine Bar passé

Offices Held

City Judge, Marawi City

Deputy Ambassador to Saudi Arabia

Deputy Ambassador to Iran

Ambassador Extraordinary and Plenipotentiary to Iraq

Commissioner, Commission on Elections (COMELEC), appointed 1988

Appointing Authority (COMELEC)

President Corazon C. Aquino

Religion

Islam

Family

Son: Associate Justice Japar B. Dimaampao, Supreme Court of the Philippines

Notability

Maranao jurist, diplomat, and COMELEC Commissioner from Lanao del Sur; among the pioneering Muslim Filipinos to hold senior positions across the Philippine judiciary, foreign service, and a constitutional commission.

Known For

He pursued a formal legal education and earned his Bachelor of Laws degree, then passed the Philippine Bar Examination, clearing the way for a career in the law. His dual fluency in Philippine statutory law and the customs and traditions of his own community would become one of the defining strengths of his early work.

Service as Philippine Ambassador to Iraq; appointment as COMELEC Commissioner under President Corazon Aquino (1988); father of Supreme Court Associate Justice Japar B. Dimaampao, the second Muslim magistrate ever appointed to the Philippines' highest court.

JUDICIAL CAREER

Dimaampao's first major public role was in the judiciary. He served as a City Judge of Marawi City, the urban center of Lanao del Sur and the cultural capital of the Maranao people.

As city judge, he handled the full range of disputes that come before a local court, from civil matters to criminal cases, all within a community where adat, or customary law, and rido, or clan conflict, could complicate even straightforward legal proceedings. His reputation in this role was built on fairness and on a practical understanding of the human dynamics of a Maranao community, qualities that made him effective not just as a legal technician but as a judge whose decisions people could respect.

His time on the bench gave him something that would prove useful in every role that followed: a ground-level understanding of how formal institutions actually interact with Muslim Filipino communities, and where the gaps tend to appear.

DIPLOMATIC CAREER

From the bench, Dimaampao moved into the foreign service, where he would spend years representing the Philippines in the Middle East. This was not a small assignment. The Middle East is among the most diplomatically and politically sensitive regions for the Philippines, both because of the large number of Overseas Filipino Workers there and because of the country's relationships with majority-Muslim nations that carry weight in international Islamic forums.

Dimaampao served in several key posts:

- **Deputy Ambassador to the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia** — the Philippines' most important OFW destination and a strategic partner in the Muslim world
- **Deputy Ambassador to Iran** — a posting that required navigating the complex diplomatic landscape of post-revolution Tehran
- **Ambassador Extraordinary and Plenipotentiary to Iraq** — his highest diplomatic rank, representing the Philippines to a country at the center of geopolitical turbulence in the region

As ambassador to Iraq, Dimaampao carried the full weight of bilateral representation, protecting the interests of Filipino citizens in the country and maintaining the diplomatic relationship through what were, by any measure, challenging years. His background as a Muslim Filipino gave him cultural credibility in these postings that few non-Muslim diplomats could have matched, a practical advantage in building rapport with counterparts and host governments in the Islamic world.

His diplomatic assignments also reflected something important about how the Philippine government was beginning to recognize, even if not always consistently, that Muslim Filipino professionals had a role to play in foreign policy, particularly in relations with the broader ummah.

COMELEC COMMISSIONER

After his diplomatic career, Dimaampao reached another career milestone when President Corazon C. Aquino appointed him as a Commissioner of the Commission on Elections in 1988. The appointment made him one of the few Muslim Filipinos to serve on a Philippine constitutional commission, a body whose work touches the very foundation of democratic governance.

At COMELEC, his responsibilities covered the full range of electoral administration: enforcing election laws, overseeing voting processes, adjudicating electoral disputes, and ensuring that the mechanics of elections ran cleanly and credibly across the country.

His particular focus, given his background, was on Mindanao, where running elections has never been a simple logistical exercise. Elections in the region have historically involved security concerns, competing clan loyalties, and the political realities of communities whose relationship with the central state has been complicated by decades of conflict and neglect. Dimaampao understood these dynamics from the inside, which made him a uniquely positioned voice within the commission for pushing toward fairer and more credible electoral processes in the south.

His time at COMELEC also placed him squarely within the broader project of making Philippine democratic institutions more inclusive of Muslim Filipinos, a goal that was still very much a work in progress at the time.

FAMILY AND PERSONAL LIFE

Dimaampao was a family man whose household was anchored in Marawi City and built around the values of education, faith, and public service. He and his wife, the late Babay T. Dimaampao, raised children in a home where the expectations of the community and the responsibilities of professional life were taken seriously.

The most visible continuation of his legacy is his son, Japar Babay Dimaampao. Raised in Marawi under his father's influence, Japar pursued a career that would eventually take him to the very top of the Philippine legal system.

Japar built an exceptional record: lawyer, certified public accountant, law professor, prosecutor, Regional Trial Court judge, and a long-serving Associate Justice of the Court of Appeals, where he rose to become the third-ranking justice before his appointment to the Supreme Court.

In September 2021, President Rodrigo R. Duterte appointed Japar Dimaampao as the 191st Associate Justice of the Supreme Court of the Philippines. He became only the second Muslim magistrate ever appointed to the country's highest court, following the late Associate Justice Abdulwahid A. Bidin, who served from 1987 to 1995. The appointment fulfilled a mandate for Muslim representation in the Supreme Court embedded in the 1976 Tripoli Agreement, the 1996 GRP-MNLF Peace Agreement, and Republic Act provisions that had gone unmet for more than two decades.

The father-to-son arc, from city judge in Marawi to the Supreme Court of the Republic, is one of the more striking stories in Bangsamoro institutional history.

PASSING AND BURIAL

Magdara B. Dimaampao passed away on July 11, 2013, at approximately 80 years of age, after a period of illness. His son Japar, then serving as an Associate Justice of the Court of Appeals, confirmed his passing.

In keeping with Islamic tradition, his body was brought first to the Masjid Al-Dahab, the Golden Mosque of Quiapo in Manila, for the ritual cleansing that precedes burial. Following the requirements of Muslim burial practice, which call for interment within 24 hours of death, his remains were immediately flown to Lanao del Sur, where he was laid to rest.

The Golden Mosque, one of the most recognized Islamic landmarks in Metro Manila, was a fitting place for the observance. Its use for the funeral rites of a man of Dimaampao's standing reflected both his faith and his connection to the Muslim Filipino community spread across the capital and beyond.

LEGACY AND SIGNIFICANCE

What Magdara B. Dimaampao represented, across his career, was the possibility of full participation. He was a Muslim Filipino from Lanao del Sur who did not limit himself to a single lane, who moved from the local bench to the international stage to a constitutional commission, and who did so with enough competence and credibility to be appointed, reappointed, and trusted with serious responsibilities in each domain.

For the Bangsamoro community, his life demonstrated that maratabat, the Maranao sense of honor and dignity, was not just a cultural value but something that could be expressed through institutional achievement. He was not a symbolic appointment or a token presence; he was a working professional who showed up in consequential roles at consequential moments.

The legacy he left most concretely is the one his son carries: a seat on the Philippine Supreme Court, held by a Muslim Filipino who grew up watching his father serve. That continuity, from one generation of public service to the next, is perhaps the most enduring thing Magdara B. Dimaampao built.

SEE ALSO

- Japar B. Dimaampao
- Commission on Elections (Philippines)
- Maranao people
- Lanao del Sur
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
- Muslim representation in Philippine institutions
- Masjid Al-Dahab (Golden Mosque, Quiapo)

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- Manila Bulletin. (2021, September 17). *Japaar B. Dimaampao is PH's second Muslim magistrate at SC.* MB.com.ph.
- Philippine Star / The Freeman. (2017, December 1). *Who, in the world, is Comelec Chairman Sheriff Abbas?* Philstar.com.
- BangsamoroPedia source biography: Magdara B. Dimaampao (compiled profile, wiki.maranaw.com editorial files).

EXTERNAL LINKS

- Philippine Daily Inquirer obituary notice, July 2013 (https://newsinfo.inquirer.net/443117/ex-comelec-commissioner-magdara-dimaampao-passes-away)
- Manila Bulletin profile of Justice Japar Dimaampao, September 2021 (https://mb.com.ph/2021/09/17/japaar-b-dimaampao-is-phs-second-muslim-magistrate-at-sc/)
- BangsamoroPedia — Preserving Bangsamoro Heritage and Achievement (https://wiki.maranaw.com)

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